

by the community, but we are yet to unlock the true potential of open source in the country.

How many of us really know that the highly sophisticated computer in our pocket is running Linux! Apple Macintosh and the iOS are based on the MACH kernel, Windows on BSD, and all of these are open source kernels. On a positive note, I would say that it is impressive to see the adoption of Android, but at other levels, the real potential of open source is yet to be realised by Indians.

Survival

You may wonder, “How did Niyam Bhushan survive and continue giving to the industry?” One should always remember that any community-building needs your time and effort, but gradually, it will start giving you returns in the most unexpected manner. This was not the real driving force for me. I love people and I love ideas. Sharing your knowledge and experiences in return brings you commercial opportunities, as well as a plethora of ideas that further enhance your understanding. My intention was never to be a multi-billionaire, but to earn more than comfortably for myself while following my passion. I wanted to touch the lives of as many people as possible and enrich my life with knowledge-sharing whenever and wherever possible.

The beauty of the community is that it seems like it is taking your time and effort, but it opens doors to lucrative opportunities as well. The community will continue to evolve around specific value-based pillars. For instance, in the vibrant startup communities of India, open source is fuelling a gold rush, propelling India to becoming a creator of wealth in the world. In academia, it is the highly local and focused communities that deepen learning and exploration. In the government and the public sector, their internal communities orient, adopt, collaborate and formulate policies.

What open source can do for:

An organisation

Free and open source software (FOSS) is a wild dragon-child that can transform any organisation into a Daenerys Targaryen. But like her, you need to know how to tame this dragon, and where and when to use this effectively. Otherwise, its fire can and will consume you instead.

An individual (home user)

Whatever software a home user adopts (including proprietary and commercial software), open source offers fierce competition to push costs down, keep it free, enhance its performance, make it secure, or honour your privacy better. Hence, open source browsers are free. Home users get operating systems for free or a token fee. The latest Firefox outclasses even Google Chrome, while Telegram messenger and Signal outshine WhatsApp with their privacy and security.

Techie home user

That's like singing to the choir. For the techie home user, open source is the best way to tinker and hack and, hopefully, also build the next billion-dollar unicorn in your barsaat!

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Dos and Don'ts for developers

I insist that people should read their employment contract carefully. In most cases in India, I've noticed developers have signed away their rights to their contributions to FOSS in the name of the company, which may even keep them a trade secret, and may even threaten employees from using their own code ever again. Even if the software is under a free, *muft* and *mukt* licence, please carefully consider whom you want to assign the copyright of your work—to yourself, or your organisation.

Check with the legal department about policies on the use of code marked as open source. Often, violations occur when developers help themselves to code without bothering to check the implications of its licence.

A ray of hope

Unfortunately, people in India are not yet sensitised enough to the issue of digital privacy. If this sleeping giant wakes up to the importance of digital privacy, the adoption of open source will naturally become pervasive. IoT will provide the next push for open source across India, invisibly. Startups and entrepreneurs are and will continue to set up sophisticated cloud-based services deployed on free and open source software. So, here's the magic bullet: sell your value-proposition, not your open source philosophy, and the market will adopt in droves. Beyond software, I see open source licences being adopted directly in agriculture, health, pharma and education, creating an exponentially larger impact than they could ever create as just software licences.

To conclude, I would say that we've managed to discover the magic formula for the adoption of free and open source software in India. Just make it invisible, and people will adopt it — hence the exponential growth in the adoption of Android in India. Arduino projects bring FOSS to kids. But for me, adoption of open source is successful when people start the relationship with it after understanding its true philosophy. This is one love affair with freedom! 